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Projects in the pipeline to increase water supply in Charles

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Alicia Afroilan, left, Charles County engineering supervisor for infrastructure management, and Jason Groth, director of planning and growth management, provide an update on the northern Charles County water supply and water projects during the county commissioners' Oct. 28 meeting.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News



Charles County is working on short-term and long-term water projects to increase the county's water supply in the northern part of the county.

Projected growth in those service areas balance economic, social and environmental objectives and provide opportunities for the regional supply, Jason Groth, director of planning and growth management for Charles County, said during the county commissioners' Oct. 28 meeting.

“Water coming in and water coming out need to balance,” he said.

The county has an existing connection with WSSC (The Washington Suburban Sanitary Commission) to purchase 1.4 million gallons of water a day, Groth said. The Route 301 Interconnection Project allows the county to purchase up to five million gallons of water a day.

The project is in the design phase for the pipeline and the water treatment facility, Alicia Afroilan, the county's engineering supervisor for infrastructure management, said.

They expect to have permits within the next two years. It is set to be completed in 2030. The projected total cost is \$90.4 million by fiscal 2030.

Charles County is only allowed to draw 20% of water that is available, Groth said. The county is staying within Maryland's “conservative measurements and cutoff for the ability to draw more water.”

The county is also working on design efforts for the Upper Potomac River Project, Groth said. The project would build a river-water intake off of Marshall Hall and could distribute up to 10 million gallons of water a day to water systems.

That long-term project is still in preliminary planning, Afroilan said. They are taking a closer look at the water quality, field work, environmental assessments and selecting final sites to start design of the pipeline, intake and treatment facility sometime around 2030.

“The county is looking at this from a perspective of looking forward to the future,” Commissioner President Reuben B. Collins II (D) said. “The issue of water supply is not limited to Charles County.”

For information and updates about both water projects, visit www.charlescountymd.gov/government/planning-and-growth-management/public-water-supply-program.